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Culture, changing livelihoods, and HIV/AIDS discourse: Reframing the institutionalization of fish-for-sex exchange in the Zambian Kafue Flats

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Abstract

Discussions about the cultural dimensions of the spread of HIV/AIDS in Africa persist. Drawing on data on fish-for-sex deals between local Ila or Tonga women and immigrant fishermen in the Zambian Kafue Flats, we argue against the notion that traditional institutions governing extra-marital sexual relationships are responsible for the spread of HIV/AIDS. We argue that fish-for-sex exchanges are based not on tradition, but on the economic opportunities provided by the fish trade in conditions of poverty and changing livelihoods. Stigmatization of women involved in fish-for-sex deals is, however, on the increase, since they are accused of spreading the disease in their community. Women's inability to follow the sexual prescriptions conveyed by HIV prevention programmes produces shame and moral distress, associated with the fear of social exclusion. In this situation, *lubambo*, a former customary regulation of extramarital sexual relations among the Ila, may provide women with legitimacy for sexual transactions. Additionally, customary marriage arrangements institutionally secure their access to fish.

Keywords: *HIV/AIDS, transactional sex, fisheries, Zambia, customary sexual relations*

Introduction

Fishing communities have only recently been recognized as being at high risk of HIV infection, due to the mobility of fishermen and fish traders, the need for and availability of cash, and the congregation of numerous people at fishing harbours and other trading places (Kissling *et al.* 2005, Seeley and Allison 2005). In the Kafue Flats of Zambia, small-scale commercial fishing has gained importance due to economic and livelihood changes (Haller and Merten 2006). Commercial fishing is dominated by migratory and highly mobile fishermen. Seasonal fishing camps provide new markets and opportunities, attracting also men and women from the local Ila/Balundwe and Tonga agro-pastoralist communities. In part, the fish trade takes place as informally institutionalized sexual transactions between women from agro-pastoralist groups and immigrant fishermen. Although the role of poverty in transactional sex has long been acknowledged (Schoepf 1992), the emphasis on a cultural dimension as responsible for the high prevalence of sexually transmitted infections in the region persists (Allen 2006, Malungo 2001). Practices such as widow

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inheritance, compensatory adultery, and arranged extra-marital relationships for women (*lubambo*) have been documented in the area in the past (Smith and Dale 1968). Local health and development professionals regard such 'traditions' as being responsible for the frequency of sexual transactions and for much of the spread of HIV.

The aim of this paper is to examine the role of traditional practices in the informal institutionalization of fish-for-sex deals in the Zambian Kafue Flats, and to consider whether and how these interact with public health messages related to HIV and AIDS. It is hypothesized that customary institutions governing extra-marital sexual relations (*lubambo*) are not the cultural basis of widespread fish-for-sex deals, but have re-emerged in a transformed way in response to livelihood changes and specific economic opportunities. In the context of plural norms, reference to formerly legitimate customary regulations may serve to protect women involved in fish-for-sex deals to some degree from social exclusion and reduce their personal distress. Additionally, such regulations institutionally secure female traders' access to fish.

We argue against a cultural interpretation as the primary reason for women's involvement in transactional sex, as it conceals ongoing impoverishment in the area and the lack of economic alternatives. It also neglects men's role in the fish-for-sex trade, thus sustaining gender inequality.

Ideology and the institutionalization of fish-for-sex deals

To investigate how trading interactions between individuals are structured and institutionalized in a wider macro- and microeconomic context, we draw on the theory of New Institutionalism in economic anthropology (Ensminger 1992, Ensminger and Knight 1997). This approach incorporates a socio-economic and political framework and the analysis of ideology to investigate informally institutionalized sexual transactions.¹ Ensminger argues that a change in regulations depends on the bargaining power of the actors, as influenced by external factors. Drawing on her arguments, we investigate who can set up rules, or informal institutions, for fish-for-sex exchange, and how these rules influence risk-taking with respect to HIV and AIDS. This includes the development of informal regulations for current fish-for-sex deals, and the transformation of *lubambo*, which previously regulated extra-marital relationships involving payments.

Knight and Ensminger (1998) do not try to explain social change purely in terms of economics. They include ideology, or worldview, in their framework, and point to its strategic use in particular situations. However, they do not discuss how ideology is historically produced and linked to power, or how it influences individual identity, subjectivity and practices. To investigate the significance of a particular ideology in setting up norms and moral values, and to discuss how individuals position themselves vis-à-vis normative moral values and truth messages related to sexual behaviour, which might contradict actions taken pragmatically, we draw on scholarship informed by Foucauldian theory (Petersen and Bunton 1997, Obrist 2004). Foucault (1986) has analysed how power in modern society interacts with individuals and manifests itself in everyday practices and self-regulation. In his later writings (Foucault 1986: 36–45), he distinguished between authoritative power and power embodied in everyday practices, guided by moral codes, whereby individuals constitute themselves in different ways as moral subjects.

Foucault highlighted the role of biomedicine as central to this constituting process. Medical experts distinguish between normal and pathological physical states, and increasingly expanded their expertise to cover social and psychological behaviour. They

identify health risks and provide behavioural guidelines for their avoidance, producing moral authority. Health promotion messages are usually in line with national policies and programmes, as experts do not operate independently of health policies. Behaviour-oriented prevention in particular relies on strong moral codes as it depends on the internalization of key health messages by individuals. It is based on the readiness of individuals to accept the salience of scientific expertise and on confidence that reducing risk is beneficial. Beyond having a positive impact on health, adherence to ideologically strongly underpinned practices is associated with respectability, while failure to comply with public health messages may evoke stigma (Petersen and Bunton 1997, Obrist 2004).

In many sub-Saharan African countries the health sector is historically closely linked to Christian missions (Vaughan 1991). Health promotion programs, which are informed by ideas of modernity and development, are thus at the same time expected to conform to Christian morality. But as in the case of HIV prevention through the use of condoms, moral goals can be conflicting, leading to contradicting health promotion messages and curbing their effectiveness (Pfeiffer 2004).

The relative absence of reliable medical care in the colonial and post-colonial era also makes uncritical internalization of key health messages unlikely (Vaughan 1991, see also Lock and Kaufert 1998), and alternative explanations may instead inform perceived causes, for example HIV and AIDS (Liddell *et al.* 2005, Gausset 2001). Given these conditions, it has been questioned whether biomedicine has actually become authoritative for everyday practices in Africa (Vaughan 1991). Following up this hypothesis in post-colonial Tanzania, a study on cleanliness and hygiene concluded that key health messages presented in post-colonial health education programmes had been internalized irrespective of individual adherence to key health messages (Obrist 2004). Individuals positioned themselves vis-à-vis a health and development discourse as moral subjects reflecting on their practices related to hygiene. However, as essential premises for putting public health programmes into practice were lacking, individuals were unable to meet expectations and took pragmatic action. Simultaneously, their inability to comply with health education messages engendered a feeling of shame if they were forced to admit their failure to meet expectations.

Taking up Obrist's argument, we hypothesize that female fish traders have internalized key messages of the HIV/AIDS discourse about risk behaviour as moral norms. However, economic constraints and a lack of alternative income-generating opportunities promote sexual transactions despite the risk of HIV infection and moral sanctions. Institutions such as *lubambo*, the formalized extra-marital relationship, enable women to legitimize such sexual transactions in order to maintain respectability.

Research setting and methods

The data presented in this paper was obtained between 2002 and 2005, in Chiefdom Nalubamba (Mbeza), one of the six Ila chiefdoms in the Kafue Flats of Zambia, located approximately 200km southwest of the capital Lusaka. Mbeza covers about 1500km² on the south bank of the Kafue River and numbers approximately 27,000 inhabitants, mainly Ila and Plateau Tonga agro-pastoralists who live in scattered hamlets in the woodlands bordering the floodplain. During the dry season, the floodplain is used as a grazing area for cattle. Several fishing villages and seasonal camps of migratory fishermen are also located in the floodplain, along the river and lagoons.

The agro-pastoralists' social organization is based on a bilateral kinship structure, whereby married women move to their husband's location (virilocality), although there are exceptions. Hitherto, a bride-price of four to eight cattle is expected from the husband, which is distributed between the wife's relatives and herself (usually one animal per entitled person). Approximately 25% of the agro-pastoralists' households are polygynous, comprising mainly wealthier families. In all types of households the average educational level of women is relatively high with 6.9 years, and 7.1 years for men (data from adults aged 20 years and above in 374 households).

The fieldwork, conducted over two 6-month periods, included participant observation in an Ila settlement in the woodlands and in fishing villages aimed at gaining an insight into local livelihoods, power structures and politics. Six focus group interviews were conducted on the subject of fishing activities and related problems. Another six focus group interviews were carried out on the topic of HIV/AIDS. In addition, semi-structured interviews on fishing, trade, and related problems were conducted with 84 fishermen in two fishing camps. Fifty-seven fish traders (26 female, 31 male) were interviewed using a similar interview guideline. Sixteen fishermen and 26 female traders were asked about fish-for-sex deals by local fieldworkers, who, to ensure confidentiality, came from a different area. In addition, seven local female fish traders from the woodlands, who were willing to reveal their fish-for-sex activities, were interviewed in depth. Four women were living in the neighbourhood of the compound where we stayed during the fieldwork, so we were able to follow their activities and stay in continuous contact with them over the 3 years. We limit the focus of this paper to fish-for-sex activities, in which women from the permanent local Ila/Balundwe and Plateau Tonga settlements were involved.

Results

The economic crisis, livelihood change, and substituting strategies

New Institutionalism (Ensminger 1992) allows us to link macro-economic and local changes to social norms and institutions. Changes such as these were crucial to the development of informal fisheries and trading structures in the Kafue Flats. Since the 1970s, when copper prices declined, the Zambian economy has come under increasing pressure. Many employees and workers in industrialized areas have lost their jobs in the formal sector. Small-scale farmers have also been affected. After 1964, the post-independence Zambian government subsidized agricultural production and prices for maize meal. When the state stopped buying maize at a fixed price in the early 1990s and withdrew other agricultural subsidies, maize production decreased (Mickels Kokwe 1998). Women, reliant on maize as a cash crop, were among those most affected. The economic crisis of the 1980s and 1990s was accompanied by a deterioration in veterinary disease control and added to livestock loss among the formerly wealthy agro-pastoralists in the Kafue Flats (Fielder 1973, Nambota *et al.* 1994).

Meanwhile, demand for fish increased in the growing urban centres. The relative price of fish compared to other agricultural commodities rose disproportionately (twice as much as maize), fuelling a rush into an expanding fishing sector (Haller and Merten 2006). The women of the Kafue Flats' agro-pastoralist groups used to fish in the tributaries near the permanent settlements for subsistence or local sale. When fish prices escalated, commercial fishing took over and began to jeopardize women's traditional but informal access to the tributaries. Women continued trading fish, but increasingly went to the large fishing camps

on the river and the lagoons to buy fish from commercial fishermen, or to exchange sex for fish. Trade with the migratory fishermen was facilitated by a long history of interaction with the most important groups. This was particularly true of the Lozi fishermen: the Lozi used to raid the area for cattle and slaves, and later on bartered fish in exchange for milk with the agro-pastoralists. They came to be regarded as 'cousins' of the Ila, facilitating the establishment of trading and marriage relationships. Most fishermen spoke the local language.

Fish-for-sex exchange and the absence of alternatives

As we are trying to feed our families, we are involved in fish trading. So we go to the fishing camps and there we are sometimes involved in sexual activities. When we are involved in sexual activities we can get AIDS and then eventually we die. (Community health worker, focus group interview, Mbeza, 2004)

It was often said that local women 'go to the flats with nothing and return with a lot of fish'. Sexual transactions between local women and commercial fishermen in the floodplain were regarded as a necessity to meet livelihood needs, despite the threat of HIV infection. Fish-for-sex deals could be requested by a fisherman (the transaction is then called *miyambilo*) or based on mutual consent, but the women's motivation was always economic. In fish-for-sex deals, material gains were the main motivation for the relationship, consistent with definitions of transactional sex (Caldwell *et al.* 1994, Arnfred 2004, Luke and Kurz 2002, Mzinga 2004).

For local female fish traders from the woodlands villages in the Kafue Flats, fish-for-sex exchanges were not necessarily the only option to generate income, but by far the most lucrative. Women turned to fish-for-sex exchanges when the opportunities were best. The following two examples highlight the opportunities such deals may have for female traders.

In the first example, an elderly widow from a woodlands village describes how she became involved with a fisherman. She was planning to barter maize flour for fish in a fishing camp in order to resell the dried fish in her village. Her family had a cattle camp near the fishing area and good relations with some of the fishermen, providing her with an entry point to the fishing camp and allowing her to stay there to process the fish. During her stay, she was approached by a fisherman:

So when I reached there, I was advised by a certain man: 'If you want to buy more fish, if you want to get more fish, it's better to find a man who catches fish for you, and that man will be able to give you more fish. And with the money you have, it is better for you to keep it, you don't show it to him'. After that, I also agreed, and I found a man (this same man), who was willing to help me. He gave me a lot of fish, and when I came back here I managed to get three 90-kilogramme bags of maize. (Female fish trader in Mbeza, aged 55, 2004)

Using such a strategy, she gained 270kg of maize at once, enough for more than 6 months of home consumption.

Another widow from a woodlands village, in her 40s, had a relationship with a fisherman at the river, whom she visited about once every two months. She obtained fish for free as long as she stayed in his house, and was able to sell the fish he caught. During the rainy season between December and February, when the fisheries were officially closed and fishing was prohibited, women involved in petty trading were least likely to be caught by fisheries officers, and so were able to generate an income during the 'hungry months' before

the maize harvest. The widow indicated that particularly at this time of year, women from town, but also from the woodland villages, were involved in sexual transactions (some were married and had to support families):

There are now [in December 2002, when fishing was prohibited] about 300 men still there [in the fishing camp]. Women from town also visit the camp. They brew beer and exchange it for fish, fresh fish and then they dry it ... There are women who have boyfriends there so that they can get the fish. I saw about five women from Mbeza who I know are married ... I came to the fishing camp to see if the fish was ready. I stayed for a day ... then I came back to Mbeza where I got a lift in the car of A [to Lusaka to sell the fish] ... I am not going to give any money to the boyfriend [in the fishing camp]. Actually it was an agreement. I stay with the boyfriend and get [all] the fish. (Female fish trader in Mbeza, aged 42, 2002)

Like the first woman, this widow was able to make large profits on her own behalf from a single trip to town, gaining up to US\$100. This represents a little less than a nurses' monthly salary and exceeds profits from other income-generating activities.

Bargaining power structures interaction: who can set the rule?

Fish-for-sex deals were not always based on mutual consent. As long as there were few female traders, men competed with gifts to find a 'wife' for their household. In this situation, women had considerable bargaining power to define the nature of the relationship, but power relationships changed as more female traders arrived. Particularly when fish were scarce and competition between traders substantial, fishermen's bargaining power with female traders increased, allowing them not only to define the rules of the transactions, but also to reduce their commitment to the female traders. The common request 'no deal, no fish' forced many women into sexual activities they did not want. Female traders either had to agree to fish-for-sex deals, or they had to wait, sometimes for days, to purchase fish. In addition, women became increasingly vulnerable to fraud: some female traders tried to book fish by paying in advance, but never received their merchandise.

Female traders made decisions under ambiguous conditions. They were well aware of their particular opportunities to increase profits in situations of scarcity, which contributed to the attractiveness of fish-for-sex exchanges. Yet women only got involved in sexual transactions without resentment if they could control the nature of the relationship and maintain their respectability. Women indicated their preference for a steady relationship, a 'marriage' although without a bride price, if they were to be involved with a fisherman, and expected commitment from the man. Such arrangements also decreased the likelihood that a fisherman would deal with other women as well, which represented a major concern for female traders.

The [intruding] female traders disturb our marriages ... And this can bring poverty to the camps, because the fish that [other traders] are given can reduce our income. The female traders are given free fish, despite the fact that we, the married women, own the nets. (Female trader from Likenga fishing camp, 2004)

Non-formalized marriages or relationships, which were sometimes called *lubambo* (formerly institutionalized extra-marital arrangements), provide the women with an institutional framework for fish-for-sex transactions, which is different from prostitution. This provides a basis for reducing transaction costs for the women engaged: time saving access to the

catches of the fisherman, and a safe location to stay and process the fish, thus clearly better opportunities than other traders had. On the basis of such 'marriages' and the related transactional obligations, which economically set the framework for the material transfers, women claim parts of the catches as theirs. Such a strategy also provides an ideological basis for trying to prevent the 'husband' dealing with other female fish traders.

Regaining legitimacy through former institutions

The economic considerations of sexual transactions are accompanied by moral reflections and the weighing of health risks. In this second part of the paper, we focus on how female traders and fishermen, position themselves vis-à-vis prevailing norms as moral selves in the context of HIV/AIDS discourse, and how they perceive their risk of becoming infected.

Sexual networking and transactional sex have shifted to the centre of discussions about the spread of HIV infection in Africa (Caldwell *et al.* 1994, Alary and Lowndes 2004). The focus of the public health discourse on urban female sex workers as a major source of infection has influenced local perceptions of HIV and AIDS (Gausset 2001). In the permanent villages of the Kafue Flats, this has increased pressure on female fish traders, who have become associated with 'prostitution' because they are suspected of fish-for-sex deals.

None of the women we interviewed referred to their activities as prostitution, but spoke instead of traditional or temporary marriage. The two widows we cited above referred to the customary institution of *lubambo*, which had formerly regulated extra-marital relationships of Ila women, and lent not only formalization but legitimacy to the arrangement. *Lubambo* as a transformed institution offered women involved in transactional sex a framework in which, based on mutual consent, the material transaction was legitimized and regulated.

The reference to institutions like *lubambo* took place in spite of criticism expressed through the health and development discourse and Christian ideology (the latter being indirectly linked to ideas of development by defining the replacement of heathen customs as progress). The critique of traditionalism was moderated by the lack of a single doctrine embraced by the various Christian denominations (Luig 1997: 269). An alternative emerging cultural heritage discourse, drawing on ideas of traditionalism, nationalism and ethnicity, was promoted by political groups (Merten and Haller 2005). Within this context, traditional institutions such as *lubambo* were viable.

The transformation of lubambo

Social institutions are not inalterable cultural facts, but transform according to the context and changing power relations (Ensminger and Knight 1997). The institution of *lubambo* has undergone fundamental change in response to external influences. The changing meaning of *lubambo* over the past century mirrors the ongoing process of social and economic transformation, and changing gender relations. These are important to understand the current connotation of the term, oscillating as it does between 'marriage' and 'prostitution'.

According to Edwin Smith, a missionary, and Andrew Dale, the first administrator of the British South African Company in the district, who arrived among the Ila in 1902, it was possible for a married woman to have an official lover (*mambakwe*), who was presented to the whole community in a ceremony. *Lubambo*, as the arrangement was called, not only

legitimized and institutionalized extra-marital sexual relations, but also involved a formalized transaction of gifts, implying a commitment to maintaining the relationship. These gifts were part of a social security network. Until today, a *mambakwe* can supply a woman with commodities her husband cannot provide in times of scarcity (Merten and Haller 2005). Smith and Dale (1968) described *lubambo* as follows:

[Lubambo] is a recognized institution ... It differs from an ordinary system of paramours, in that there is a public ceremony, so that everybody knows of it, even the woman's husband. He cannot throw stones at his wife because he does the same ... Husbands naturally exhibit great complacency in regard to this custom. To their minds it is the best policy, for they benefit by it. (Smith and Dale 1968, volume 1: 66–67)

Brelsford, a colonial administrator during the 1930s, considered *lubambo* to be a source of income for the husband, who offered his wife to another man.

The word [lubambo] itself means literally 'an arranged thing' ... the arrangement of the relationship lies between the lover and the husband of the woman, and it is not *lubambo* until husband and lover have met and discussed the affair ... After the first gift of a head of cattle, the husband may desire more, and he still may not be satisfied if he considers that his wife is making more visits to the lover than is proportionate to the payment. (Brelsford, undated, Namwala District Notebooks)

Brelsford interpreted the exchange of gifts not as formalizing an arrangement like Smith and Dale did, but as payment. This may in part mirror the effect on social relations of monetization and integration into a market economy during the early colonial years.

During this period, the authority of the elders evidently began to be challenged by the younger generation due to their increasing economic autonomy. Marriage had hitherto figured as the cornerstone of local social organization, as the elders controlled the cattle needed for bride price payments (Ensminger 1992). In this context, 'female promiscuity', implying a lack of control over marriage arrangements by elders, was observed with some concern: it was considered indicative of social instability and feared by local and colonial rulers alike as detrimental to local power structures and political stability (Chanock 1998: 149; 159, see also Vaughan 1991: 130–139). This is illustrated by a comment from Chittenden, who was the colonial administrator in the 1950s. He lamented women's growing economic strength, which he perceived to be the consequence of modified 'traditional prostitution':

The advent of the plough, which started to become fairly common in the late twenties and early thirties, started an agricultural revolution that was not without its impact socially on the tribe. It was recorded in the middle 30s in an annual report that the change to the plough had become so common that the women, on whom previously the main work of tilling fell, had now on account of the plough, so much leisure that they were able not only, as was traditional, to prostitute themselves on their husbands' behalf but now on their own behalves as well, and that they were now even becoming property owners. (Chittenden, April 1958, Namwala District Notebooks)

However, what Chittenden observed was actually the simultaneous occurrence of female economic autonomy and impoverishment, which he failed to differentiate. Women's loss of control over agricultural production was the more likely cause of the sexual transactions observed: The emerging maize market and the advent of the plough motivated men to take over maize production and claim ownership of their wives' fields. This was possible in part due to the virilocal sedentary pattern, which strengthened men's position with regard to

land ownership. The economic status of women was also said to be deteriorating during the colonial era in other parts of Africa (Allman 2001). The number of impoverished unmarried women increased along with the emerging urban and industrial centres, labour migration and resettlements. Such a development could also explain the increase in sexual transactions observed in the Kafue Flats.

On the other hand, changes in the legal system during colonial times had increased women's bargaining power with respect to property ownership and compensation payments. In the later colonial period, Cutshall (1980), a social anthropologist, reported that women frequently figured as successful plaintiffs on their own behalf in cases regarding property ownership.

Female fish traders, stigma and shame

Historical notes from early colonial times suggest that female sexuality was by no means 'permissive' in traditional society, even if *lubambo* enabled women to some extent to engage in desired extra-marital relationships. But a woman could never do as she wished without the consent of her husband. Only within these boundaries, were female extra-marital relationships, involving gifts and payments, socially sanctioned and morally legitimate.

Lubambo in its early sense was arranged and formalized, and not promiscuous. Sex-work, in contrast, is a phenomenon closely linked to labour migration, urbanization, and impoverishment, and is strongly stigmatized. Sexual transactions such as fish-for-sex deals may today fluctuate between these two extremes. When women talk of *lubambo* in the context of fish-for-sex exchange, this does not involve an arrangement between a husband and a *mambakwe*. It merely implies that the sexual transaction appears to be within the bounds of a legitimate relationship. However, it depended on the context whether the concept of *lubambo* reduced women's stigmatization. Women carefully avoid admitting involvement in fish-for-sex exchange, or in a *lubambo* arrangement, in front of a health professional, or a church member, for example who might consider her a prostitute and associate customary marriage regulations with primitiveness.

In the context of HIV and AIDS, women's sexual behaviour has remained the central concern (Lugalla *et al.* 2004). In the Kafue Flats, female traders are popularly represented as the source of HIV infection. Women described sexual transactions as illicit if they could not assign their relationships legitimacy. Particularly in a context informed by ideas of modernity and Christianity, personal distress can be considerable. A female fish trader from the woodlands, divorced for over 10 years and a member of the Seventh Day Adventists Church, spoke of the social stigma and shame that derived from fish trading:

The reason why I stopped going there [to the fishing camp] was because people they created a lot of stories about me ... They were saying that I have a man. So when it came to my mind, it pained me a lot. So that's why I stopped. (Female fish trader living in Mbeza, 2004. She temporarily stopped trading fish, but resumed her business later on)

In contrast, women who identified with a 'traditional' lifestyle, which was indirectly legitimized by the cultural heritage discourse of local leaders, made strategic use of the customary concepts of *lubambo* to legitimize sexual transactions towards themselves and the community. Particularly problematic with respect to HIV, however was the tendency to reject condom use in steadier partnerships, relying on a mutual promise of faithfulness of partners (see also Maharaj and Cleland 2005).

Men and fish-for-sex deals: Ineffective HIV/AIDS prevention?

Criticism of male involvement in sexual transactions was uncommon and usually linked to the risk of an HIV infection, and not to immoral behaviour. Never would a man face stigmatization because of a sexual relationship with a female trader, even if in the local socio-political environment, male involvement in sexual transactions is not uncontested. In the Kafue Flats fishing camps, some established commercial fishermen are strongly critical of fish-for-sex deals.

While economic interests and livelihood needs, in view of the given opportunities, outweighed the risk of contracting HIV for women, men had no need to take such risks. Their non-compliance with HIV prevention messages was seen as an example of recklessness:

The fishermen know that there is HIV/AIDS, and what they do is [the following:] because most of the traders who come to the fishing camps look healthy, so they cannot know that they have that disease, that's why they engage themselves in sexual activities with them. It is after they have done their act, when they are sick, that they realize, that person whom I did the act is sick. (Commercial fisherman in Likenga fishing camp, 2004)

It has to be borne in mind that opportunities to invest the available cash are limited, particularly for young and inexperienced fishermen and workers. Their ability to spend money on alcohol and women is a way to position themselves socially in accordance with their earnings and to gain reputation (which is less relevant for well-established commercial fishermen).

The visibility of people living with AIDS has been related to risk perception in the relevant literature (Bowser 2002). This may partly explain why risk perception was low in the fishing camps with their highly mobile population, where sick people are the exception as they often return to their home villages. Also, the fishermen's high-risk profession may make other dangers seem more immediate than HIV infection (Kissling *et al.* 2005).

But structural constraints also have to be considered. The nearest clinic, where treatment of sexually transmitted infections, counselling on HIV and free condom supply were available, was over 20km away. Condoms were rarely available in the camps at the time of the study, even though demand existed, and protection was therefore ineffective. Uncertainties like these spurred demand for alternative means of protection and nurtured supernatural explanations for the acquisition of the disease (cf. Gausset 2001).

None the less, the fishermen's risk perception was also informed by public health messages: female traders from rural areas were considered less likely to be infected with HIV compared with women from urban centres. Engaging in an institutionalized marriage or *lubambo* arrangement, and the provision of large amounts of fish, were believed to increase the faithfulness of a female partner. Such attempts to prevent HIV/AIDS, which mainly consisted in the control of sexual partners, indicated that key HIV prevention messages and moral norms have been internalized by the fishermen, even if they clearly underestimate their risk of becoming infected.

Conclusions

In the above discussion of fish-for-sex deals in Kafue Flats, we have shown how in a Foucauldian sense, the internalization of competing norms can be understood as a basis for individual actions, which are however embedded in a living context and a framework of changing livelihoods. Ensminger (1992) adds much to our understanding of immediate

aims and individual action in a specific context dependent on external variables, economic settings, and the bargaining power of actors.

Throughout this paper, we have presented evidence to counter the assumption that customary institutions regulating sexual transactions, such as *lubambo*, are primarily responsible for the occurrence of fish-for-sex deals. We have outlined the role of economic opportunities due to external changes in relative prices (greater increase for fish compared with other agricultural products), and of livelihood changes, which create a need for income-generating alternatives. We conclude that the general economic crisis and local livelihood changes were the primary reasons why women engaged in transactional sex, while the fishermen profited from women's economic dependency.

There is a generally high level of knowledge about HIV related risk and prevention among the Zambian population (Central Statistical Office 2003, Slonim-Nevo and Mukuka 2005), and the female traders were aware of the possibility of acquiring HIV through fish-for-sex deals. Nevertheless women faced problems in protecting themselves (see also Bond and Dover 1997). Behavioural HIV/AIDS prevention messages have been internalized and shaped local moral norms: faithfulness between partners was regarded as the 'right behaviour', illicit sex as dangerous. However, female fish traders often lacked the bargaining power to refuse a sexual relationship especially when competition between traders increased, either because of blackmail ('no deal, no fish'), or because they could not afford to turn down a very favourable offer from a fisherman. The expected profits due to the high relative price of fish, in view of livelihood needs, may outweigh the fear of infection or social stigma. In this context, female traders made reference to customary marriage arrangements, which represented an alternative moral code to the health and development discourse.

Arrangements with fishermen were often called 'marriage' within the fishing camps, and female traders pragmatically referred to *lubambo*, assigning a certain degree of legitimacy and safety to sexual transactions. Despite the radical transformation of the meaning of the term, *lubambo* has maintained the idea of legitimacy of sexual transactions in particular local settings, where traditional values were re-emerging as a result of local political dynamics. *Lubambo* provided an institutionalized framework for sexual transactions which was different from prostitution, allowing women in a poor socio-economic setting to retain their self-esteem vis-à-vis the dominant health and development discourse by redefining transactional sex as a legitimate traditional practice. However, this was only feasible in a situation of plural norms. It pragmatically served to maintain female traders' respectability to some extent in a 'traditional' local setting, while they experienced more personal distress and stigmatization in a more modern social context or as church members. The persistence of customary marriage arrangements also has an economic side: it institutionally provides a framework for material transactions, which secures a female trader's access to fish, thereby increasing her opportunities.

Fishermen were generally in the stronger position, socially as well as economically—they controlled the fish, which provided them with more bargaining power. This allowed them to play down their role in the transmission of HIV and define the rules for sexual transactions (see also Lugalla *et al.* 2004).

There are several implications for HIV prevention. First, it should be considered that criticism of customary 'temporal' marriages may disempower women who use transformed customary regulations strategically to insist on commitment from their 'husbands'. Second, it is crucial to concentrate preventive efforts on men, as they are in the economic position to control their relationships with female traders. Third, income-generating alternatives for

women, although important, cannot be a substitute for the high profits from fish trading. Options for fishermen to invest their earnings instead of giving away the fish to female traders may be more likely to reduce fish-for-sex deals. Finally, although condom use has been shown to be a successful strategy in Zambia's urban areas, and among sex-workers elsewhere (Fylkesnes *et al.* 2001, Ghys *et al.* 2002, Alary *et al.* 1999), condoms were not available in the fishing camps, although some beneficial effect could probably be expected. Structural barriers in access to health care facilities for highly mobile populations and in remote areas should be considered. Public health key messages can only be turned into action if a basic infrastructure is provided (see also Obrist 2004).

One limitation of our study is the fact that we did not have any data on current infection rates. Neither could we quantify sexual transactions, or the different forms of relationships. However, these occurrences largely depend on a rapidly changing framework. The intention of this paper was rather to explore how economic and livelihood change, changing social institutions, and different ideologies shape health-related action, a process which is not restricted to the Kafue Flats area. In this respect, qualitative information can add to the understanding of individual strategies, and contribute to better-focused health interventions in similar settings.

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Notes

1. Ensminger and Knight have shown how changing socio-political, technological, demographic, and economic conditions provided the basis for the abolition of the bride-price and clan exogamy among the Orma in Kenya. Institutional change occurred in part as a consequence of external economic change: altering relative prices increased the economic opportunities of the younger generation, strengthening their bargaining power and facilitating a change of marital institutions in their favour. Ideology was strategically used to enforce particular interests.

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Résumé

Les débats sur les dimensions culturelles de l'expansion du VIH/sida en Afrique se poursuivent. En exploitant des données sur les transactions poisson-contre-rapports-sexuels, entre les femmes Ila ou Tonga et les pêcheurs immigrés dans les Kafue Flats en Zambie, nous remettons en question l'approche selon laquelle les institutions traditionnelles qui régissent les rapports sexuels extra conjugaux sont responsables de l'expansion du VIH/sida. Nous soutenons que ces échanges ont pour base, non pas la tradition, mais les opportunités économiques offertes par le commerce du poisson dans un contexte de pauvreté et de changements de moyens d'existence. La stigmatisation des femmes impliquées dans les transactions poisson-contre-rapports-sexuels est cependant en augmentation, puisqu'elles sont accusées de répandre la maladie dans leur communauté. Leur incapacité à suivre les recommandations des programmes de prévention du VIH en matière de sexualité a pour conséquence un sentiment de honte et de détresse, associé à la peur de l'exclusion sociale. Dans ce contexte, le *lubambo*, un ancien mode traditionnel de régulation des rapports sexuels extra conjugaux chez les Ila, pourrait offrir aux femmes une légitimité pour les transactions sexuelles. De plus, les mariages arrangés traditionnels institutionnalisent la garantie de leur accès au poisson.

Resumen

Aún persisten las discusiones sobre la dimensión cultural del contagio del VIH/sida en África. A partir de datos extraídos de los intercambios sexuales a cambio de pescado entre las mujeres locales de Ila o Tonga y los pescadores inmigrantes de la zona de Kafue Flats en Zambia, nos oponemos a la idea de que las instituciones tradicionales que gobiernan las relaciones sexuales extramaritales sean responsables de la propagación del VIH/sida. Argumentamos que las transacciones de pescado por sexo no se basan en tradiciones sino en las oportunidades económicas ofrecidas por el comercio pesquero en condiciones de pobreza y cambios en los medios de vida. Sin embargo, el estigma de las mujeres que

participan en el intercambio de pescado por sexo es cada vez mayor y se les acusa de extender la enfermedad en su comunidad. La incapacidad de las mujeres para seguir las prescripciones sexuales que se divulgan en programas para la prevención del virus del sida produce vergüenza y ansiedad moral asociada al temor de la exclusión social. En esta situación, el *lubambo*, una antigua normativa de costumbres que afectan a las relaciones sexuales extramaritales entre los Ila, podría ofrecer a las mujeres legitimidad en las transacciones sexuales. Además, los acuerdos matrimoniales según la tradición aseguran de un modo institucional el acceso al pescado.